

Summer Palace / Pari Mahal (Sheesh Mahal Basement)

گرمائی محل / پری محل

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Not separately documented from the Shah Burj Quadrangle building programme
- Built in: Shah Jahan's reign
- Cost: Not documented
- Built for: A cool underground residence for the imperial household during Lahore's hot summer months

2. Construction Details

- Form: A labyrinth of underground chambers beneath the Shah Burj Quadrangle
- Access: Historically reached from the upper Sheesh Mahal, or via the later British-built Hathi Pul entrance; tunnels reportedly connected it toward the Ravi River, plausibly for escape in case of attack, though this specific purpose is partly speculative rather than confirmed

3. Historical Background

- Used by Maharaja Ranjit Singh during the Sikh period; later served as a storage repository for the British Civil Defence Department during World War II, and continued to be used for storage in Pakistan as late as 1973 - meaning a space built for royal comfort spent much of the 20th century as a military and civil storage depot instead.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- The idea of tunnels running from this basement toward the Ravi River, possibly as an escape route during an attack, is a genuinely documented physical feature - the tunnels exist - but their precise original purpose is partly inferential rather than certainly proven.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Below the shimmering Sheesh Mahal lies a second, hidden palace built purely to escape Lahore's summer heat - a place meant for royal comfort that, centuries later, would spend the Second World War stacked with civil defence supplies instead of silk cushions, its cool stone chambers repurposed for a war its Mughal builders could never have imagined.